Into the Woods

By Stephen Sondheim and James Lapine

Suggested Roles: ***Actor:*** *Baker, Witch, Cinderella, Rapunzel*
Actress: *Narrator, Wife, Jack, Little Red*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NARRATOR: **(Pg 3-4)** Once upon a time in a far-off kingdom lived a childless baker with his wife. **(Pg 12-14)** The baker had lost his mother and father in a baking accident – well, at least that is what he believed. He was eager to have a family of his own and concerned that all efforts until now had failed. *(a knock on the baker's door)*

BAKER: Who might that be? *(looks off to see)* It's the witch from next door! *(opens the door)* We have no bread.

WITCH: Of course you have no bread! *(Wife reacts)*

BAKER: What do you wish?

WITCH: It's not what ***I*** wish. It's what ***you*** wish. *(points to wife's belly)* Nothing cooking in there now, is there? *(Wife reacts by clutching her stomach)*

NARRATOR: The enchantress went on to tell the couple she had placed a spell on their house.

WITCH: In the past, when you were no more than a babe, your father brought his young wife and you to this cottage. They were a handsome couple, but ***NOT*** handsome neighbors. My beautiful garden! How was I to know what your father had hid in his pocket? My mother had warned me I would be punished if I ever were to lose any of the beans.

WIFE: Beans?

WITCH: The special beans! I let him go / I didn't know / he'd stolen my beans! *(getting worked up – she raps)* Then Bang! Crash! And the lightning flash! / And I laid a little spell on them. *(Rap stops)* You too, son – that your family tree would always be a barren one. *(wife gasps; Witch begins to rap again)* So there's no more fuss/ And there's no more scenes / And my

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garden thrives - / You should see my nectarines! / But I'm telling you the same / I tell Kings and Queens / Don't ever never ever / Mess around with my greens! / Especially the beans.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Our story begins in a kingdom where fairy tales don't just happen.*
ACTOR: *They get a little tangled, slightly ridiculous, and occasionally burst into rap at the worst possible moments.*
ACTRESS: *Welcome to a world where cows are suspiciously important, and happily-ever-afters come with a long list of conditions.*
ACTOR: *In this enchanted forest, wishes don't come true easily -- and if they do, there's usually a catch or a curse!*
ACTRESS: *Are you brave enough to go . . .*
TOGETHER: *Into the Woods by Stephen Sondheim and James Lapine*
ACTOR: ***(whispers)*** *A great adventure is about to begin.*

WITCH: (Pg 16) You wish to have the curse reversed? I'll need a certain potion first. Go to the wood and bring me back . . . One: the cow as white as milk, Two: the cape as red as blood, Three: the hair as yellow as corn, Four: the slipper as pure as gold. Bring me these before the chime of midnight in three days' time, and you shall have, I guarantee, a child as perfect as child can be. Go to the wood! *(the witch disappears in a puff of smoke) (The Baker and his wife prepare to leave for the wood. As the Baker dons his father's old coat, he finds something in the pocket)*

BAKER: (Pg 17) Look what I found in Father's hunting jacket. *(holds out his hand)*

WIFE: *(Looking at his hand)* Six beans

BAKER: I wonder if they are the–

WIFE: Witches beans? We'll take them with us!

BAKER: No! You are not coming.

(Baker exits, leaving his wife at home)

NARRATOR: (Pg 18) And so the baker, reluctantly, set off to meet the enchantress's demands.

BAKER: (Pg 27-29) This is ridiculous. I'll never get that red cape, nor find a golden cow, or a yellow slipper – or was it a golden slipper and a yellow cow? *(Wife sneaks up behind him and taps him on the shoulder; he jumps in fear)* Oh, no . . . .

WIFE: The cow as white as milk, the cape as red as blood, the hair as yellow as corn, the slipper

BAKER: *(cutting her off at any point)* What are you doing here?

WIFE: *(tries to put a scarf around his neck)* You forgot your scarf –

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BAKER: *(taking the scarf off)* You have no business being alone in the woods. Now go home!

WIFE: I wish to help!

BAKER: No! The spell is on ***my*** house. **WIFE:** ***Our*** house

BAKER: Only ***I*** can lift the spell

WIFE: We must life the spell ***together***. *(noticing a young boy with a white cow)* A cow as white as . . . Milk!

BAKER: Hello there, young man. What might you be doing with a cow in the middle of the forest?

JACK: *(nervous)* I was heading toward market [to] sell my cow, sir. No less than five pounds. But I seem to have lost my way.

BAKER: Five pounds! Where am I to get five pounds? *(Searches his pockets)*

WIFE: And if you can't fetch that sum? Then what are you to do?

JACK: I hadn't thought of that . . . I suppose my mother and I will have no food to eat.

BAKER:*(holding out his hand to his wife with a few coins and the beans)* This is the sum total . . .

WIFE: *(loudly)* Beans – we ***musn't*** give up our beans!

JACK: Beans in exchange for my cow?

WIFE: Oh, these are no ordinary beans, son. These beans carry ***magic***.

JACK: *(excited)* Magic? What king of magic? **WIFE:** *(to Baker)* Tell him.

BAKER: *(nervously)* Magic that defies description . . . **JACK:** How many beans?

BAKER: Six.

WIFE: Five! We can't part with all of them. *(takes one of the beans and puts it in her pocket)* Besides, I'd say they're worth a pound each, at the very least.

BAKER: *(hands Jack the beans as wife takes the cow's lead)* Good luck there, young lad. *(to Wife)* **(Pg 31)** Take the cow and go home. I will carry this out in my own fashion. *(Baker and Wife exit in separate directions)*

******* (Another part of the woods) *******

BAKER: **(Pg 31-32)** *(steps into Little Red Riding Hood's path)* Hello there, little one.*(aside)*[The cape as red as blood] *(to Little Red)* Where did you get that beautiful cape?

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LITTLE RED: My granny made it for me.

BAKER: I would love a red cloak like that.

LITTLE RED: *(giggling)* You'd look pretty foolish.

BAKER: *(grabbing the cape)* May I take a look at it?

LITTLE RED: *(in a panic)* I don't like to be without my cape. Please give it back! Please!

WITCH'S VOICE: Forget the little girl and get the cape! *(Baker tucks the cape under his arm and dashes away)*

LITTLE RED: *(stands numb for a moment then lets out a bloodcurdling scream)*

******* (Another part of the woods) *******

(Cinderella dashes onstage, looking over her shoulder)

WIFE: **(Pg 37)** Are you all right, miss?

CINDERELLA: *(breathless)* Yes. I just need to catch my breath.

WIFE: What a beautiful gown! *(focusing on her shoes, not the gown) (aside)* **(Pg 27)** The slipper as pure as . . . **(Pg 37)** *(to Cinderella)* Were you at the King's Festival?

CINDERELLA: *(preoccupied with the people who are chasing her)* Yes. . . What brings ***you*** here *(notices the cow)* and with a cow?

WIFE: Oh, my husband's somewhere in the woods. *(proudly)* He's undoing a spell. *(moving to the shoes)* Now, the Prince, what was he like?

CINDERELLA: *(creeped out)* **(Pg 39)** I must get home! *(runs away)*

WIFE: Wait! I need your shoes! *(begins to chase Cinderella. Cow moos; she changes direction to chase the cow)* Hey. Come back here!

******* (Another part of the woods) *******

BAKER: **(Pg 40)** *(looking at his watch)* One midnight gone.

WIFE: **(Pg 45-46)** *(coming up behind him; she startles him again)* I see you've the red cape.

BAKER: Yes. Only two items left to locate.

WIFE: Three.

BAKER: WHAT HAVE YOU DONE WITH THE COW!

WIFE: She ran away. I never reached home. I've been looking for her all night.

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BAKER: *(upset)* I should have known better than to have entrusted her to you.

WIFE: She might just as easily have run from you!

BAKER: But she didn't! **WIFE:** BUT SHE MIGHT HAVE! **BAKER:** BUT SHE DIDN'T!

WITCH: *(appearing from nowhere)* WHO CARES! THE COW IS GONE! GET IT BACK! GET IT BACK!!!!

BAKER: I don't like that woman. *(they exit in opposite directions.)*

******* (Another part of the woods) *******

WITCH: **(Pg 57)** Two midnights gone!

WIFE: **(Pg 51)** *(to herself)* I hope there are no witches to encounter

RAPUNZEL: *(sings a tune without words)*

WIFE: *(hears Rapunzel's singing and sees her glorious hair as she brushes it near the tower window)* **(Pg 27)** The hair as yellow as corn! **(Pg 51)** *(calling up)* Rapunzel, Rapunzel? Let your hair down to me.

RAPUNZEL: *(Dubious)* Is that you, my Prince?

WIFE: *(in a deep voice)* Yes. *(Rapunzel lowers her hair out the tower window)*

(Wife yanks her hair three times. Each time Rapunzel's song is interrupted by the tugging. On the third yank, Rapunzel screams and the hair falls into the Wife's hands. She runs away)

******* (Another part of the woods) *******

BAKER: **(Pg 53)** *(enters dejectedly leading the cow by a rope, he spies his wife)* I thought you were returning home.

WIFE: You've the cow! **BAKER:** Yes. I've the cow. We've only two of the four.

WIFE: Three. *(reveals the hair she was hiding behind her back)* Three! **(Pg 27)** The hair as yellow as corn! **(Pg 54)** And I almost had the fourth, but she got away.

BAKER: We have one entire day left. Surely, we can locate the slipper by then.

WIFE: **(Pg 85)** I wish *(Suddenly notices a golden slipper on the ground; she squeals in delight)* **(Pg 65)** The slipper! We've all four!

WITCH: *(appears out of nowhere)* **(Pg 67)** The third midnight is near. You've all the objects? **(Pg 68)** Feed the objects to the cow! You heard me. Feed them to the cow! *(the Wife mimes*

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feeding the items to the cow) Now fill this! *(hands over a goblet, and the Wife milks the cow and hands the goblet to the Witch who drinks it down)*

BAKER: **(Pg 69-70)** We've given you what you wish.

WIFE: Now when can we expect a child?

BAKER: What's wrong? What's happening. *(the Witch begins to shudder and move away)*

WIFE: *(suddenly very pregnant)* Wait. Where are you going? *(the Witch turns around with a flourish. She has been transformed into a beautiful woman)*

NARRATOR: The witch, who had been punished with age and ugliness that night when her beans had been stolen and the lightning flashed, was now returned to her former state of youth and beauty.

WITCH: **(Pg 73)** *(raises her arms to put a spell on the Baker and his Wife once again, but only a pathetic puff of smoke comes from her hand. She tries again. No success)*

NARRATOR: As is often the way in these tales, in exchange for her youth and beauty, the witch lost her power. **(Pg 74)** And it came to pass, all that seemed wrong was now right. The kingdoms were filled with. Ever after. *(The witch snorts in derision and stomps off).*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier

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